MyScoutee

I

PART ONE OF THE MYSCOUTEE TRILOGY

The Story

The City Between Us

A founder's memoir of rooms, routes, and the path between people

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A first-person public edition. Autobiographical memory is kept distinct from verified product capability and future product outcomes.

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A Note to the Reader

This is a memoir-based account told in the first person. It is also the origin story of a product that is still being tested.

The rooms, journeys, conversations, mistakes and moments of kindness come from my memory. Names have been removed, some sequences have been compressed, and a few uncertain locations remain deliberately unnamed. Where memory and public geography meet, I prefer an honest question mark to invented precision.

All character and scene illustrations in this book are artificial intelligence (AI)-generated visual interpretations. They do not depict the actual participants.

This story compresses decades. Adjacent pages, and especially adjacent seconds in the companion film, do not necessarily describe events from the same year or events that followed one another immediately. Where a year changes the meaning, I state it. Where only the emotional connection matters, I preserve the bridge without pretending that a lifetime happened in one continuous season.

MyScoutee is a built software core, not a claim of proven social outcomes. It does not promise a perfect partner, guaranteed chemistry or complete safety. The idea is simpler and more difficult: help mutual intention travel far enough to become a real, freely chosen meeting.

This first part ends with that invitation. The consequences of the next chapter in my working life belong to Part II.

Prologue — The Cognac Notebook

The notebook is still on my desk.

Its cover is the colour of cognac held against a window at dusk: brown until the light reaches it, amber where the years have worn the surface smooth. I carried it through rooms that never quite became homes, opened it on trains and buses, and filled it with systems long before I knew which system I was trying to build. Some pages contain numbers. Some contain routes. Others contain sentences that stop halfway across the paper, as if they too were waiting for somebody to answer.

When I look back now, I do not remember my life as a straight line. A village field becomes a railway track. The railway becomes a tram wire over Budapest. The wire becomes the blue-white route of the Victoria line. A wet London window becomes the glass of a bus somewhere between mountains. A pencil mark becomes a network.

Memory edits without asking permission.

Yet one question survives every cut: how can a world crowded with people leave so many of us without a path to one another?

That question did not begin with an app. It began much earlier, with soil on the hands of my family, three disciplines in my mind, a diploma still waiting behind one missing language certificate, a city of extraordinary beauty, and the strange discovery that a person can have a place to sleep without having a place in life.

MYSCOUTEE ORIGIN STORY

Part One — Ground



1. What the Soil Teaches

My ancestors were small agricultural producers. I do not say this to construct a romantic countryside that never existed. The soil is not sentimental. It is seasonal, physical and exact. Something is planted or it is not. Rain comes or does not come. Work leaves a mark that can be seen.

At eight, I decided that I wanted to become a programmer. The machine that first held my attention was a Commodore 64, but I was drawn to more than the rules beneath its games. I watched their backgrounds: small constructed worlds in which code, colour and atmosphere occupied the same limited screen.

That double attention never left me. Programming rewarded precision. On my journeys, paintings and historic buildings drew me toward forms that could look mathematically exact and still carry the beautiful irregularity of the hands that had made them. I wanted to understand both: the structure that held a thing together and the human trace that kept it from becoming sterile.

That inheritance stayed with me even when my own tools became mathematics and software. I trusted systems that could be understood, work that could be tested, and effort that produced a visible result. I was less prepared for the invisible systems surrounding human acceptance: the rooms offered through friendship, the jobs decided through impressions, the circles that opened only when somebody inside already knew your name.

Like many young people from the countryside, I moved toward Budapest for study and work. It was not because the countryside had no dignity, and it was not because every Hungarian journey must end in the capital. It was my route. The station platform was small; the expectation attached to it was enormous.

Before university, I loved to run. I entered races and learned to think in breath, rhythm and distance. Natural ability helped, but what running taught me was that breathing and endurance usually mattered more.

In one secondary-school race, classmates caught hold of my arms and tried to pull me back. I still finished first.

I do not turn that finish into a parable about defeating other people. What I remember is the rhythm returning after the interruption: breath finding its place again, and the line still waiting ahead.

People usually read me as quiet and restrained. They did not expect the wilder part. I was never quick-tempered; I might let anger reach my voice once in three or four years. When I finally spoke without softening it, the surprise could silence a room. Reserve was not the same as fear.

I studied economics, programming and mathematics together. In Hungarian, the degree has a name that sounds almost like three professions trying to occupy one line. I liked that. Economics asked what people valued. Mathematics asked what could be proven. Programming asked whether an idea could be made to run.

Years later, those three questions would return together.

2. Budapest, Beautiful and Distant

Budapest never looked like a city one should need to escape.

The Danube divides it and holds it together. From the Pest side, Buda rises in layers: Castle Hill, stone walls, church towers and slopes that catch the last light. From Buda, Pest opens into boulevards, tram lines and the long ceremonial geometry of Andrássy Avenue. Yellow trams move beside the river as if somebody had drawn a bright line through history. Steam rises from thermal water in winter. Museums, concert halls, markets, cafés and old cinemas offer more lives than one person could inhabit.



One person can reach a beautiful city and still remain outside its human conversation.

The beauty continues beyond the city. The Danube bends through Szentendre, Visegrád and Esztergom. At Visegrád, the river curves below the citadel; at Esztergom, the basilica rises above the water and the border. Gödöllő holds a palace and park close enough for a day. The Buda hills begin before the city has fully ended, with caves, forest paths and the chairlift lifting ordinary afternoons above the roofs.

I knew I came from a beautiful place. That knowledge made the loneliness more confusing, not less.

I finished university in 2004. Because my dissertation had slipped behind its original schedule, the earliest I could have collected the diploma was 2005. Even then I could not collect it: one intermediate-level foreign-language examination was still missing. In reality, I received the diploma considerably later. My first attempt to establish myself in Budapest did not become a settled move. For about a month, relatives let me stay in their large house. There was physical space, and I do not claim that they treated me badly, but I felt that I was imposing on their life. The work that had brought me there did not match what the employer had led me to expect. I felt deceived, and I returned to my parents.

After that, Budapest became a series of one-day attempts. I travelled up for job interviews several times, with the employment centre reimbursing the cost of the journey to the capital. A ticket could carry me to an interview and back, but it could not yet turn the city into a life. Each trip began with possibility and ended with another return to my parents' home.

The Cornfield and Trivandrum

The professional door finally opened in October 2005, about a year and a half after I had finished university. At that moment I was not sitting in an office or waiting beside a polished reception desk. I was hoeing between rows of corn.

I joined an Indian company that October, and almost immediately the route carried me to South India. I spent about a month and a half in Thiruvananthapuram, also known as Trivandrum, working with an Irish and Hungarian team. The city is Kerala's capital near the far southwestern edge of mainland India: low coastal hills face the Arabian Sea while the higher country of the Western Ghats rises to the east and northeast. It already belonged to an established technology landscape, but the place I encountered could not be reduced to an office or a software park.

The district includes famous visitor beaches. The particular shoreline that stayed in my memory felt very different: I practically saw no tourists there. That is a memory of one beach, not a claim that southern Kerala had no tourism. What mattered was the sudden scale of the change. A man who had just been working a cornfield was now learning how to work inside a South Indian city, with the sea at the edge of it and several national habits meeting inside one team.

That was where I began to learn English in practice. Until then, English was also the formal obstacle between me and my diploma: I still needed the intermediate-level language certificate required before I could collect it. In Trivandrum, the language became less an examination subject than the ordinary means of asking, answering, misunderstanding, correcting and completing work together. It became usable; it did not yet become easy. This was my first international work environment, where a missing credential began to become a usable human skill.

The Indian company opened the professional door. On paper, the sequence now looked correct: countryside, university, international work, capital city. Yet the route into stable adult life was far less legible than the route printed on any tram map.

When I first came to Budapest for work, I stayed in a workers' hostel. It was impersonal, but its impersonality had rules. A bed was a bed. A key was a key. The difficulty was that late work could bring me back after the room had been locked. On some nights, the corridor became the only remaining space. I learned how fluorescent light changes when you are trying to sleep beneath it.

Encounters Without a Reliable Room



Different openings, different constraints: no person can be reduced to the first visible problem.

Human possibility did not wait politely for my housing problem to end.

A woman from Debrecen came to Budapest for another commitment — perhaps some kind of lecture or presentation, although I no longer remember exactly. Before it, we spent about three hours on a date. I was strongly attracted to her. When our time was up, we walked together to the venue for the programme that had originally brought her to the city. Along the way she linked her arm through mine. At our quick goodbye she gave me a slightly shy kiss on the cheek, then went to her programme. I could not invite her to stay because I was living in a workers' hostel, though she did not know that—I had kept it to myself. Where I left the circumstances unexplained, she formed her own picture of me and at one point described me as poor. Only later, once she was home in Debrecen, did she write in a chat that she should have kissed me instead of giving me only that shy kiss on the cheek.

Even a three-hour date required us to coordinate an intercity journey and the other commitment that had brought her to Budapest: when she would arrive, where we could meet, when we had to reach that programme's venue, and which return would close the available window. Attraction did not remove geography or competing plans. The journey, her purpose in the city and our time together had to fit inside one another.

Her message remained with me because it arrived after the moment in which it could have changed anything. She eventually found a partner and moved to Budapest. About a decade later, we met again. I read anger in the way she looked at me, but I cannot know what that expression contained. Memory can preserve a face; it cannot safely invent the other person's inner account.

Another woman entered my life without an app or an introduction. In a shopping centre, she approached me, sat down beside me on a bench and began with Chinese and Western astrology. It was spontaneous, direct and almost impossible to design: a stranger created the opening herself, and conversation existed before either of us had prepared a profile.



The absence of private space still shaped what followed. Even the possibility of being together was difficult to plan. One day ended on Margaret Island: one of Budapest's most generous public spaces standing in for a private room neither the hostel nor our circumstances could provide.

Attraction did not remove distance, timing or missing context.

Later, at her family home, a frightening family and health crisis revealed how much important context I had not known. I took a day away from work to accompany her to care in another city. The relationship ended. Her diagnosis, treatment and family details are not mine to publish. The part that belongs to my story is more limited: spontaneous attraction can be real, while needs that two unprepared people do not understand remain invisible until a crisis.



For a while, I found a private room in Budapest. I was not told that I was only replacing somebody for the summer. When the previous circle wanted the room back, the arrangement changed around me. The precise address and the people do not belong in this book. What mattered was the difference between a system I could see and acceptance I could not predict.

Sometimes a stranger created the opening herself.

I returned to the workers' hostel. Its rules were strict and its atmosphere anonymous, but anonymity sometimes felt safer than a welcome that could be withdrawn without warning.

Later, I moved into an ordinary shared flat with three genuinely separate bedrooms. They were not passage rooms through which residents crossed to reach one another's space. For the first time in this sequence, the arrangement gave each person a normal boundary and enough room.

A third encounter began through an online dating site and happened there. This time the physical space existed, but a ready-made story about me arrived first. I felt immediately stereotyped. The first judgment softened enough for a single night, but not into a shared future.

There was another online introduction before London in which the other woman wanted to continue getting to know me. This time I cannot blame the room, the train or an absent shared context. I became frightened by the possibility of commitment and stepped back. That memory matters because a system did not break every unfinished path. Sometimes I was the person who closed it.

I do not present these women as mistakes or myself as the innocent centre of unfinished stories. Attraction, hesitation, dignity, money, housing, health, timing and expectation were different in every case. We all arrived with problems, and we all risked turning one visible problem into a judgment about the whole person.

A relationship is not the selection of somebody whose life contains no difficulty. It is the slower work of learning what is real and deciding whether two people can accept one another and continue through problems together. That does not mean hiding essential context, abandoning boundaries or enduring harm. It means refusing to confuse a quick label with a complete human being.

In these memories, judgment often arrived before understanding, while important context sometimes arrived too late. Mutual possibility appeared. What we lacked was enough shared truth, time and structure to discover whether we could move forward together.



Space existed; a complete shared future did not automatically follow.



Sometimes the Founder was the person who stepped back.

3. The Key My Parents Gave Me

 ventually, my parents helped me acquire a flat.

That sentence is short enough to hide the weight inside it. Their help gave me material security at a time when many Hungarian families entered foreign-currency mortgages that later became traps. I did not take that route. I cannot know what would have happened in an alternate life, and I do not claim that every borrower made the same decision or faced the same outcome. I only know that my parents' help placed a solid key in my hand.

The key solved a housing problem. It did not solve belonging.

Budapest remained beautiful outside the window. I had work. I had an education. I had a place that was mine. I still felt that the surrounding human world was conducting a conversation from which I had missed the opening sentence.

This is one of the hardest forms of solitude to explain. Nothing is obviously wrong. The lights are on. The bridges are full. Exhibitions open, musicians play, friends meet friends, and couples find one another in ways that appear effortless from the outside. A person can live among all of it and remain unconnected.

The final work sequence before London made that separation impossible to ignore. Through my previous employer, I spent roughly four or five months working in the United States. Our temporary base was a hotel on the outskirts of Baltimore, and we had a company-rented car. The geography that opened around the work was astonishing. We reached Ocean City on Maryland's Atlantic coast, Virginia, Philadelphia and Washington; travelled between Baltimore and New York by Greyhound; saw Niagara Falls; and visited Amish country. At roughly the Washington–Baltimore latitude, Six Flags lay to the east. Farther inland to the west, we walked what I knew as an Indian Trail along a wooded mountain-top ridge.

In Adams Morgan, I remember women smiling and sometimes making the first approach. I do not turn that into conquest or a claim about American women. What stayed with me was the social lightness of the gesture: for a moment, contact did not feel like a test I had already failed.

The most surprising feeling arrived on the return from New York toward Baltimore. Somewhere on that journey, I felt for the first time that I was going home. “Home” meant a hotel outside Baltimore and a temporary working team, not a permanent address. The feeling showed how quickly repeated routes and familiar people can give borrowed geography an emotional centre.

That American period was therefore not black and white. It was a dream of scale, movement and possibility, but it contained very little private life. Work consumed most of it. In my account, I was driven extremely hard after overtime had been promised. When the assignment ended, I returned to the Hungarian office and continued working there for a time. The promised overtime payment did not follow me home. The hours had already been worked. As the promise grew older, they seemed to be turning into free labour after the fact. I could not make that transformation feel ordinary. Friction grew. I eventually left the employer. I keep the company anonymous because this is my memory of what happened, not an adjudicated claim in this book.

Before London, I tried to recover the overtime I believed had been promised. At a hearing, my lawyer sat beside me. Afterwards, in the corridor and within my hearing, the office manager raised the possibility of work for the lawyer's son. “We will see. Let us not discuss it here.” I could not know what the exchange meant. I knew what it did to my trust.

At the end, I told my lawyer that I would leave for a country where I hoped the rules would be followed more reliably. He did not seem to understand what I could mean. I did not yet know England either. I knew only that the corridor had made departure feel more rational than one more attempt to be heard at home.

I left around September 2010.

What followed was six and a half months without work. The last Hungarian interview process I remember was with a small company. It continued through four rounds; the fourth included psychological testing. After all of that, the company still did not hire me. The test itself is not the accusation. What stayed with me was the expanding sequence of gates, effort and uncertainty that still ended at a closed door.

I did not leave because Budapest was ugly or empty. The unpaid promised overtime, departure from that job, six and a half months of unemployment and one last four-round rejection became the final sequence in a much longer experience of not moving forward. England was no longer simply an adventure. I experienced it as an escape toward a labour market in which I might still find a usable door.

There was also a frightening physical reason for urgency. Blood in my stool had first appeared during the extreme work pressure of the American assignment. I connected the symptom to that pressure, but this memoir does not turn my interpretation into a medical diagnosis. By the time I left for London in 2011, I was still carrying that symptom and fear. My Hungarian public-health-insurance coverage was no longer active. In London, I received medical care. I keep the diagnosis and clinical details outside this public account; the relevant truth is that the journey began with vulnerability as well as ambition.

The London ticket was not a rejection of home. It was an attempt to find a door.



MYSCOUTEE ORIGIN STORY

Part Two — The House Inside London



4. The City Opened in Two Stages

 arrived in London in 2011. The Diamond Jubilee and Olympic summer did not bring me there; they came the following year, after the first work, health and housing thresholds had already begun.

I brought one suitcase and the professional identity I understood best: I was a programmer. Despite my weak English, I found work in London within two weeks. In Soho, I wrote software in a compact office among colleagues from different countries. For almost three years, however, I could barely speak with them. Trivandrum had made English usable; London exposed how far I still was from an easy social voice.

Outside, the streets changed character every few metres. A theatre queue gave way to a record shop, a café to a private doorway, a Chinese restaurant to a small gallery. The same wet pavement reflected ten different worlds.

London did not ask me to understand it before entering. It allowed me to enter first and remain confused in public.

That was a kind of freedom.

Then, in 2012, the Diamond Jubilee and Olympic summer filled public space with temporary confidence. The city seemed to be introducing itself in every language at once. That exceptional summer became part of London's early magic, but it was not the date or reason for my arrival.

There were museums where a person could spend a day for the price of the journey, exhibitions that opened unexpected rooms in the mind, clubs, public lectures, late cafés and dates across cultures. Accents changed from desk to desk. At first, much of that human world reached me as sound before it became conversation. Humour crossed borders imperfectly and sometimes became funnier because of the effort.

Sometimes the office carried me into that social world. Once, the company took us to eat pizza in the gardens of Regent's Park. On another day, I tried sushi on a Soho terrace. I disliked the first mouthful so completely that I rushed into the women's lavatory to spit it out. When I emerged, relieved and slightly embarrassed, a beautiful woman smiled at me. For one absurd second, I felt that I could have married her on the spot.

Nothing came of it. London could still compress embarrassment, beauty and possibility into a doorway only a few seconds wide.

When a Polish man colleague was preparing to leave, we began looking for a farewell gift. An Indian woman colleague suggested an artificial penis, something like a vibrator, from a sex shop. It was her idea, and the two of us went into a Soho sex shop to buy it for him. The gift was an affectionate insult: a way of telling him that he was a fucking dick. We liked him, and he understood the joke. What stayed with me was how naturally three people from different countries could share a joke that depended on affection rather than nationality.

Another Indian woman colleague—not the colleague from the farewell-gift memory—once told me that I should write a novel. I worked in that one London workplace through all five years. I did not write the novel then.

A Black colleague also invited me to a wedding. The invitation itself felt like acceptance, but I did not go. I was still an Eastern European immigrant, not the culturally effortless international person I sometimes hoped to appear to be. I feared entering a celebration whose codes I did not know and revealing the culture shock I was trying not to show. Years later, the sharper shock would come not from somebody else's ceremony but from returning to my own country and discovering that home had become the room I could no longer read.

For the first three years, the city felt inexhaustible.

5. The Performance of Not Being Hungry

My colleagues went out for lunch together, and I went with them. In Soho, lunch was not only food; it was where the workday became human. People loosened, told stories, complained and laughed. Farewell lunches gave the table another purpose: somebody was leaving, so everybody made time to sit together.

It was also expensive.

I was afraid that London would consume my money before I had built any future there. I opened the menu, looked at the prices and performed another version of myself. I sat at the same table and watched my colleagues eat. If somebody noticed, I behaved as if hunger had simply failed to arrive and made it sound like a Hungarian habit rather than a private calculation.

Away from the table, much of my food came down to muesli and two-litre bottles of milk. In the fourth or fifth year, I finally ate with the group once or twice. Their surprise showed how completely the performance had worked.

When the line on my private chart began to look as if it might actually reach the financial independence for which I had come to London, my focus narrowed this far. Every avoided lunch seemed to move it a little closer. The graph could record the saving. It could not record what I watched from the other side of the table.

I do not blame my colleagues. I did not tell them the truth, and they had no reason to know it. That is precisely why the memory matters. Social exclusion does not always look like a door being slammed. Sometimes a person protects himself by presenting the version that costs least to explain. The performance works, and because it works, nobody sees the need underneath it.

By day, I was a competent programmer in Soho. At lunch, I remained visible while the need disappeared.

6. Ten Lives Under One Roof

At night, the Victoria line carried me north-east to Walthamstow, and the last part of the route continued toward Mansfield Park and the Lee Valley.

The journey appears only briefly in my memory: carriage glass, a reflected face, the dark tunnel interrupted by stations, then the door of a low-rise, flat-roofed shared home beside the canal. At its busiest, as many as ten Hungarian adults lived there, including me.



Ten lives in a crowded home, with the canal, reservoirs and open Lee Valley beyond the roof.

The flat had roughly four and a half rooms. Inside, space was negotiated by the inch. Outside, the roof opened onto something astonishingly wide: canal water, reed beds, reservoirs, birds and the green reach of the Lee Valley. Mansfield Park rose nearby. Roughly a kilometre away, the Lee Valley Athletics Centre trained athletes for London 2012. A crowded home stood in one of the most beautiful places in which I had ever felt confined.

London outside was radically multicultural. The house inside was a compressed map of Hungary.

We were not identical migrants arranged around a single explanation. One person had left after a family was damaged by a foreign-currency loan. Another came to learn English. Somebody wanted adventure. Somebody was restarting below the level of his qualifications. A night worker returned when others were leaving. A hospitality worker folded an apron beside a private plan. Someone sent money home. Someone had worked for two years and still could not save enough for the return journey he had imagined. Someone lost his money through poker and had to recalculate everything.



Four different routes into the same house: family pressure, language, professional restart and social discovery.

One full bathroom served the house, with one separate toilet. I shared a bedroom. Every shelf, mirror and quiet telephone call required negotiation.

Yet the house was not a tableau of defeat. People ironed shirts before dates, translated messages, borrowed umbrellas, studied, laughed, failed, tried again and made room for one another because there was literally no other way to move through the hall.

In my rough memory, perhaps one person in three around that household and its circle no longer wanted to return to Hungary. This is not a measured statistic; I would never print it as one. It is the emotional proportion I remember. Some kept family photographs and precise return plans. Some were undecided. Some had formed local ties. Others seemed to have stored the idea of return somewhere they no longer opened.

They could be materially poorer in London and still feel happier there.

That contradiction stayed with me. A home can preserve roots and still contain loneliness. A crowded rented room can be difficult and still contain more human life. Prosperity, shelter, home and belonging are related, but they are not the same thing.

7. The Stranger Who Snored

 ne night, I went to sleep sharing the room with one person and woke to the sound of another.

The change announced itself through snoring.

The flatmate who had lost his money through gambling had exchanged his place with an acquaintance. No formal transition reached me. Darkness fell on one arrangement; morning revealed another adult silhouette in the same zone of the room.

There is pain behind that story, and I do not make the debt or the person into a joke. The humour belongs to the housing system: a human life could be replaced overnight while the furniture remained more stable than the residents.

The different snore was a perfect edit. It contained loss, adaptation, embarrassment and survival in one sound.

Years later, when I thought about software that remembers whether people have actually met, I remembered how easily human context can disappear. A person can enter the same physical space without an introduction and become only evidence in the morning.

8. The First Three Years and the Fifth

 he shared bedroom was a bargain I made consciously. The money saved through sharing paid for journeys while the low cost base also allowed savings to accumulate. For a time, the bargain felt temporary and therefore light.

The first three years passed in wonder. Work, museums, colleagues, nightlife, dates and low-cost travel kept opening the world faster than the room could close it.

By the fourth and fifth years, repetition changed the meaning. The same commute, the same rent, the same negotiated space and the same calculation began to look less like a bridge and more like a permanent structure. Alternative housing felt too expensive and unmanageable. That pressure mattered, but it was not the whole reason I returned, and my employer was not the enemy of the story.

What changed was my sense of time.

Temporary hardship can feel almost adventurous when the future remains open. The same hardship becomes heavy when a person realizes that the future has been waiting outside the room for years.

London had not lost its magic. I had begun to ask what the magic was building.

In December 2015, I looked again at a private diagram through which I had been tracking the route toward financial independence. This was not a projection of future independence. The diagram showed that what I had saved was enough for financial independence in Budapest.

The location mattered. Budapest was much less expensive, and the flat my parents had helped provide before London was available to me. It had stood empty throughout the five years I lived in London. In Budapest, the savings and the flat changed the calculation completely. In London, I had never been financially independent.

The London number contained a trap. I had accumulated the savings while living throughout my London years in a shared bedroom. A normal private home in London would consume too much of what I had built, while remaining in the same shared room would turn a temporary bargain into my permanent life.

Housing became my stop-loss. I use that phrase deliberately: the boundary beyond which staying would either spend away the Budapest independence I had reached or require me to keep accepting a life I could no longer inhabit.

That recognition placed me in front of my greatest fear. I had reached the financial target for a viable life in Budapest, but I could not build a viable London home around it. I left London with very little explanation. The company asked whether I wanted to make a complaint. I said no. The real reason had never been the company; it was the question of whether I could direct my own life without waiting for another institution to grant permission.

On some visits home from London, I used online dating in Budapest while hiding that London was where I actually lived. I wanted to enter the immediate local possibility without letting the distance define me first. But the distance would have defined any continuation, and withholding it prevented the other person from judging the real plan. The concealment was mine.

During that period I also met a former colleague who, in my memory, had barely noticed me while I was living in Budapest. The new encounter became intense almost immediately. She spoke in the language of love and of wanting a child before there was enough shared life for me to understand what the declaration meant. I interpreted the suddenness as a wish for motherhood attaching itself to me, rather than love growing from knowledge of me. That was my interpretation, not access to her private motive. What I can say safely is that speed without shared context frightened me, while my own hidden London life made the context less complete from the other direction too.

I sometimes imagine how different those years might have felt if a fast, group-first local path had already existed. It could not have promised me a partner or removed the price of housing. It might have helped the city's extraordinary variety become recurring human context sooner: a small local group, a shared activity, another invitation, and people who no longer vanished when one event ended.



Speed and incomplete context moved in both directions.

London could have been better still—not because its magic was false, but because more of that magic might have become belonging. This is a counterfactual hope, not a product result I can prove.

In December 2015, after almost five years, I came home.

Not because the first three years had been false, but because they had been real—and were no longer enough.

MYSCOUTEE ORIGIN STORY

Part Three — Global Routes, Local Encounters



9. The Fare Was One Pound

 ravel began in London as an argument with limitation.

I could not buy comfort, so I bought movement. Once, an overnight coach to Edinburgh cost one pound. The price turned sleep into an optional extra. I spent the night inside the shared atmosphere of strangers, including the unmistakable smell of somebody else's socks, and arrived in Scotland carrying fatigue as proof of admission.

I went because the adventure was larger than the inconvenience.

From Edinburgh, the country opened farther. Loch Ness replaced the contained geometry of London with water, weather and distance. On the River Clyde in Glasgow, a powerboat transformed the industrial waterfront into speed, spray and bridges. At a ticket counter, a German tourist considered the price for his child too high. I was short of money by London standards, yet for a moment the usual economic relation was reversed: the German tourist was the one who could not cover the child's ticket, and I, the Hungarian stranger beside him, almost paid it for him.

Travel revealed parts of me that ordinary life kept hidden. Thrift could live beside generosity. Fear could live beside curiosity. Exhaustion could become a story before it had even ended.

This is what I mean by a global route becoming a local encounter. The map takes you somewhere. A person, a voice, a price, a misunderstanding or an unexpected act gives the place human scale.

10. The Extra Day Nobody Had

 once planned a road circuit from London through Manchester, Liverpool, Barmouth and Cardiff, then back to London. Five of us travelled: two couples and me. I cannot drive, so we rented a car and one of the acquaintances travelling with us drove it. He was part of the group, not a hired driver. I designed the route, the sequence and the timing. We used budget hotels along the way.

The plan worked. That was almost the problem.

The rented car followed the itinerary with impressive precision. In Manchester, brick, industry, libraries and new glass occupied the same streets. Liverpool opened toward the Mersey, the Pier Head and the old docks. At Barmouth on the North Wales coast, two lines of hills seemed to lead the eye toward the sea. At low tide we could walk far onto the exposed shore and look back at the town held against the slope. Cardiff added castle stone, arcades and the broad movement toward the bay.

Everything happened on time. Everything happened too quickly.

The route had three days. Nobody travelling with me could make a fourth day available, and that missing day compressed a beautiful circuit into an exercise in endurance. The car had five people and the plan reached every stop. What the journey did not have was slack.

Years later, when I designed a path in which one invited person could decline and another could freely accept an available place, I remembered this journey. The point was never to replace friends as if people were spare parts. The point was to admit that willingness and availability are different facts. A plan can fail even when everybody likes the idea. A humane system should preserve the relationship and still allow the event to live.

11. Nearly Fifty Countries, No Collection

Over the years I reached nearly fifty countries across Europe, Africa, Asia and the Americas.

I made most of those journeys alone, and I organized them myself. That did not mean that I moved without help. I still depended on airlines, hotels, local drivers, hosts, buses, ferries and sometimes an organized excursion. The work was in joining those pieces into one route and accepting responsibility when a handoff failed. The five-person British road circuit was an exception in company, not in authorship: I had planned that route too.

The number is true and almost meaningless by itself.

Countries are not achievements to be collected, and monuments are not evidence that a person understood a place. My strongest memories are often thresholds: somebody explains a route; a driver waits; a passenger makes space; a vendor changes tone; a host points toward what the postcard does not show; a stranger notices danger before I do; a group cooperates because a balloon has landed in the wrong field.



The route expands the world. The encounter gives it human scale.

In each new environment, I met a different version of myself. Cairo tested my ability to negotiate. India tested what remained possible when cash suddenly lost its ordinary meaning. Thailand tested my reading of offers and kindness. Russia tested my patience with official routes and my dependence on an ordinary local gesture. Norway tested my willingness to trust a chain of transport I did not control. London had begun the movement, but returning to Budapest did not end it. Some of my largest journeys came later.

The notebook therefore does not preserve a strict timeline. It preserves a principle:

> *Global route. Local encounter.*

The route expands the world. The encounter makes it real. In the difference between the two, I discover something about myself.

12. Egypt: Six Days of Temporary Trust

 planned six days in Egypt largely by myself. Through WhatsApp, one driver and local hotels, I joined Cairo to Aswan, Abu Simbel and Luxor. The itinerary was short enough to look unreasonable and precise enough to work.

I landed in Cairo around midnight. At the airport, a taxi driver told me that unofficial exchange would be better than the formal counters. His private fare felt too expensive, so I ended up sharing transport with a Sudanese married couple. I was immediately drawn to the woman, and both of them seemed amused by how little I managed to hide it. Then the taxi pulled away and their suitcases, stacked on its roof, fell into the road. Before we had properly left the airport, flirtation had become a practical problem and we already had a story in common.

I reached Giza well before eight, but the site did not open until eight. I waited outside with police carrying steel shields ahead of me and stray dogs wandering behind. When the gates opened, I went in. Before I climbed onto a camel, we agreed a price. When the ride ended, three handlers surrounded me and demanded more. If they had asked that at the beginning, I could have paid or walked away. What unsettled me was that the bargain changed once it was too late to choose.

I paid and walked back, ready to forget it. I had not noticed the posted price guidance and did not know that I had paid above it. A cheerful manager saw my expression and asked what had happened. The photograph of the camel on my phone gave them something to trace. While they searched, I sat between two armed tourism-security officers.

They eventually drove me back in a police vehicle. Asked how much should be returned, I named a figure off the top of my head. By chance, it left the final price close to the posted guidance. I would never have returned for the money on my own. By then, I only wanted the episode to be over.

What stayed with me was that strangers intervened after I had already decided to let it go.

That night, I flew south to Aswan. Its airport lay some distance from the city, and before dawn I was already on the road again. At the edge of Aswan, a stern guard stood high on an armoured vehicle beside a mounted gun. Beyond him, a police car took the lead and our convoy followed it into the desert toward Abu Simbel.

Back in Aswan, my hotel stood beside the Nile. From my room I looked across the water to a beautiful Nubian island. The room felt like a honeymoon suite prepared for two, with only one guest inside.

From Aswan, I continued to Luxor with one driver. I chose the road because it allowed us to stop at several special sights along the Nile. I visited Kom Ombo, Edfu and Esna before the road reached Luxor. The journey itself became part of the visit rather than a transfer between two cities.

In Luxor, I stayed outside the usual centre on the west bank of the Nile. In one direction lay the landscape of tombs and desert. Across the water, the lights of Luxor trembled in the river. Serious armed men watched over a tourism economy still recovering from years of fear. Ancient stone, ordinary livelihood and security occupied the same frame.

At dawn, I went up in a hot-air balloon. It did not land where a clean tourism brochure would have chosen. It came down in a vegetable plot. A wall complicated the exit. Some passengers had to pass through a private home while residents, crew and travellers worked together to remove the balloon across the boundary.

For a few minutes, nationality was less important than where to put one's hands.

On my last day, I did not want to exchange more Egyptian pounds. I still wanted a vase for my mother and needed a taxi to the airport, so I told the driver exactly how much money I had left and proposed the arrangement myself: whatever remained after the vase would become his fare.

He accompanied me on foot from shop to shop to help me bargain. The first place had damaged vases, so we continued to a better one. I could not imagine a taxi driver accompanying me like this in Europe, yet there he was, walking beside me and helping to make the same small budget solve two problems. At the second shop, he helped negotiate in a way I, as a tourist, could not have matched. At one point, the driver held his head in his hands. I told the vendor that he was now bargaining at the taxi driver's expense. The vendor laughed and let the negotiation end.

At Luxor airport, I passed through two separate security gates, a degree of layering I had rarely encountered in Europe. From there, the return became a chain of airports: Luxor to Cairo, Cairo to Athens, Athens to Budapest. Two connections carried me home.

During those six days, I also spoke with Syrian refugees. I was compressing a journey I had chosen into the time I could afford; they were trying to continue after events had made movement necessary. We were all away from where we had begun, but not with the same freedom. Everybody escapes differently.

The journey was full of such temporary networks. A hotel, a driver, a manager, a security officer, a resident, a taxi passenger—each carried me across one threshold, then disappeared from the route. The experience was rich precisely because people mattered. It was fragile because the connection had no memory.

13. India in a Cash Discontinuity

My first stay in India had shown me one southern region through work. It had not shown me the whole country. The Taj Mahal stood more than two thousand kilometres north of Trivandrum even in a straight line, inside a region with different languages, architecture, climate and everyday rhythms. I wanted to see it, so in November 2016 I returned as a tourist for a self-organized five-day journey through India's Golden Triangle.

One day went into flying there through Dubai and one into flying home. For the three days between them, I had arranged a car and driver through WhatsApp to carry me along the Delhi–Agra–Jaipur route.

The journey coincided with a sudden cash discontinuity. On 8 November, the government announced that the existing series of 500- and 1,000-rupee notes would cease to be legal tender from 9 November. It was not the withdrawal of all Indian cash, but it affected the notes on which much ordinary cash use depended. A technical decision at national scale became a human problem in every queue. People waited at cash machines. Others were paid to hold places. Exchange became uncertain. The driver I had arranged through WhatsApp sometimes became the person from whom I had to ask for entrance money.

The arrangement reversed the expected roles. I was the visitor, but I was not financially autonomous. The driver was providing transport and, for moments, liquidity.

Delhi, Agra and Jaipur did not merge into one postcard. Each had its own density, colour, traffic, stone and pace. At the Taj Mahal, another memory separated itself from the architecture. A young woman was travelling with her grandfather. On the bus behind me, I heard a pleasant voice. I turned and, for a moment, lost the ability to arrange language into anything intelligent.

We spoke briefly.

Nothing dramatic happened. Distance remained distance. I did not invent a future that the journey could not support. Still, the memory endured because a voice had turned a famous place into a specific human moment.

That is the difference between reaching a landmark and arriving in one's own life.

14. Thailand, Cambodia, and the Price of a Ride

Thailand was not a short stop. I travelled for roughly two and a half to three weeks across different regions: north, west, the eastern Gulf side and the south. Bangkok, Pattaya, Phuket, the route toward the Phi Phi Islands and the crossing into Cambodia each carried a different rhythm.

Pattaya left me comparatively neutral. Other places opened more strongly. In the south, transport often began with a repeated question: did I want a ride? Usually the offer had a price. That was not wrong; it was the local economy making itself explicit.

Once, on the way toward a pier for Phi Phi, I was walking through an unfamiliar area with many dogs. A local person stopped and offered to take me to the pier. This time no price followed. My impression was that he had read the situation before I had and decided that help mattered more than negotiation.

I cannot prove what he thought. I remember the difference in tone.

The Cambodia excursion was compressed almost beyond reason. I arrived around midnight and obtained a visa at the Cambodian entry point with far less preparation than my European bureaucratic instincts expected. I continued into Siem Reap, negotiated with a tuk-tuk driver, visited Angkor and returned to the airport by late afternoon.

What remains clear is the structure: every stage required a new handoff. Border official, driver, ticket, agreed return, another vehicle, another clock. The temples offered scale and silence; the people made the day possible.

15. Moscow, Saint Petersburg, and an Open Gate



ussia required a different kind of preparation. From Budapest, I needed an invitation for the visa. A travel agency near Oktogon helped arrange it. One office redirected me to another, and another toward the embassy. The absence of an ordinary appointment route made the visa cost several times what I had expected.

Then I arrived and did not know how to buy the bus ticket.

A Russian passenger used a monthly pass to let me through into the passenger area. I had crossed the formal border with documents, fees and repeated instructions. The final small gate opened because an ordinary person saw me standing on the wrong side of it.

Moscow and Saint Petersburg offered opposite scales. Moscow felt radial and monumental: broad approaches, walls, squares and movement arranged around power. Saint Petersburg opened horizontally through water, façades, bridges and the long light of the north. The cities were historically immense. The memory that best explains the journey is still the smallest: somebody tapped a pass.

16. Europe Within Reach

 rom Budapest, Europe often began before dawn at a coach pickup point.

Some journeys lasted only a day. Their brevity did not make them trivial. A bus created a temporary group: strangers, couples, a guide, a schedule, a fixed number of seats and a promise to return by night.

In Slovakia, the High Tatras rose beyond forest and weather. I know I visited them. The exact stop is less certain; it may have been Starý Smokovec, Hrebienok, Štrbské Pleso or Tatranská Lomnica. What I remember most clearly is the change in scale when the bus stopped: the timetable remained human-sized while the mountain did not.

Elsewhere in Slovakia, my family roots reached into the Slovak Ore Mountains. Cousins lived there, but they did not speak Hungarian. I met them only once, when I was a small child.

Austria contains several separate journeys in my memory. Vienna includes Schönbrunn—palace geometry, gardens and the Gloriette holding the city at a distance. Another route reached Klagenfurt and Minimundus near Lake Wörthersee, where the world is rebuilt in miniature. It was a strangely appropriate place for somebody who would later attempt to model complicated human systems: whole countries reduced to objects small enough to walk around, their differences preserved through detail.

The Bärenschützklamm was not Vienna and not a palace. Near Mixnitz in Styria, water and rock were crossed through a long construction of bridges and wooden ladders. Progress became physical and cooperative. Every person had a pace; every narrow section required awareness of the person ahead and behind.

Croatia and Slovenia added other one-day memories. I saw Zagreb only in passing through the coach window on the way to the Plitvice Lakes; I did not visit it as a city. Plitvice was the destination. In Slovenia, I visited Bled and Vintgar. I remember them as part of a circular walk. Ljubljana was not part of my journey.

These bus journeys later became a useful product metaphor. A complete event is not only a destination. It is members, capacity, transport, timing, place, supplies, tickets, weather and the right to say no. A person who cannot attend should not destroy the relationship or the plan. Another person may choose the open place. By the time the bus returns, strangers may have become people who can invite one another again.

17. Empty Beds, Empty Seats, Perfect Systems

 ome journeys were beautiful without producing a personal story, and that absence became part of the story.

Italy gave me what I remember as my most beautiful route: rail from Bergamo toward Naples. The exact intermediate sequence has faded, but landscape and city changed at high speed while the train held a continuous interior around them.

In Paris, I travelled as if following a compass. On different days I chose different directions: the city itself, Versailles, Disneyland Paris and routes beyond the centre. Paris was not empty of sights. The problem was deciding which direction a limited day could contain.

The Norwegian circuit I remember most closely resembles the coordinated chain from Bergen through rail, the Flåm Railway, a fjord boat, bus and rail. Each vehicle arrived to continue a route designed by people I never met. The system worked so well that it almost disappeared.

On a ferry toward Rotterdam, I booked what I remember as an approximately ten-berth cabin and occupied it alone. In Spain, a roughly three-bed hostel or university room also became private by chance. Beds existed. Compatible people did not appear merely because capacity did.

Porto and Lisbon formed a four-day contrast: granite and the Douro, then hills, light and the Tagus. Neuschwanstein rose like an image already familiar before arrival. Bavaria, the Netherlands, Belgium and the eastern United States added other waters, cities and routes. Niagara, Chesapeake, Ocean City, Baltimore, Washington—some locations remain sharper than their chronology.

In Istanbul, I was invited inside for tea and a carpet presentation. Hospitality and commerce unfolded together. The welcome could be genuine and the sales purpose real. Context prevented either interpretation from cancelling the other. Dubai then offered another scale: creek and dhow, vertical glass and roads built around distance.

Travel taught me that infrastructure can move a body with astonishing efficiency. It cannot decide who will share the cabin, the table, the story or the next journey.

18. When the World Closed

After I returned to Budapest in December 2015, I did not yet know whether I had returned for good. Part of me treated Budapest as a short break before going back to London. Another part had come home to find out whether I could make a life in my homeland work better than it had before I fled. Throughout much of this period, I blamed myself for not having been able to remain in my own country.

I had left my last Hungarian employer around September 2010. By the time I returned to the health-insurance system on 10 November 2018, roughly eight years had passed. I had not spent all of them abroad. I had been in Hungary before London, during visits and again after December 2015. But official life did not follow physical geography. I was often here, yet I seemed absent. I felt that I had disappeared.

For roughly three years, I did not register again with the Hungarian public-health-insurance system. The delay did not have one clean cause. It belonged to the unresolved decision about London, my attempt to preserve independence and my uncertainty about whether coming home had been the right choice. I felt almost invisible: in the country physically, but not fully inside its ordinary administrative or social rhythm.

Brexit later widened the gap between my British and Hungarian lives. I do not mean that no authority could have found me. I mean that work, coverage and belonging no longer formed one continuous record of a life. From inside it, I felt unseen.

This was also when many of the longest journeys became possible. Full-time work had made that duration almost impossible. Now I travelled, looked for a partner, tried every route I could think of and returned to private creative work. The freedom was real, but so was the doubt. The leap year of 2016 became a suspended year in my own chronology: I kept asking whether I had made a brave decision or a terrible mistake.

I wanted to preserve independence from a country I felt had betrayed me. Yet complete separation did not become a life either. On 10 November 2018, I gave Hungary a second chance: I registered again with the health-insurance system and began looking for work. Until that threshold, I had been searching for a partner and travelling through the world while remaining emotionally outside Hungarian society.

After roughly fifty unsuccessful interviews, a job reopened the domestic route almost by accident in August 2019. Then the world closed.

COVID-19 did not make travel impossible forever, and I will not claim that nobody can travel as before. For me, it ended the earlier feeling of carelessness. The open route was no longer innocent. Borders, health, cancellation and uncertainty became visible inside every plan.

The change clarified something that had already been forming. I loved movement, but I did not want to spend my life only passing through. I had learned to enter new countries. I had not learned how to make human continuity survive the journey.

Beauty had given me memories. Local people had made those memories alive. What I still lacked was a way for an encounter to become part of a shared future.



MYSCOUTEE ORIGIN STORY

Part Four — Rooms Full of Beginnings



19. I Came Home to Find a Partner

 had gone abroad to earn money.

I came home to find a partner.

The sentence sounds cleaner than the life around it. Returning was not a single moment in which the suitcase touched the floor and every intention became clear. Between December 2015 and 10 November 2018, partner-seeking, travel, private creative work and doubt occupied the same suspended interval. Only then did I begin consciously re-entering the country's ordinary working and institutional life. Foreign experience did not automatically create a place for me in the labour market or society. People could read the same years abroad as courage, instability, high expectations, failure, ambition or a sign that I might leave again. I could not know which story another person had already written about me.

Age also became more visible. In my own experience, it had felt less decisive abroad. At home, I increasingly felt that a number could stand in front of the person. I do not claim that age discrimination is uniquely Hungarian or absent elsewhere. It exists across labour markets and inside digital dating. My point is personal: by the time I reached the room, somebody could already believe the most important fact about me was how many years I had lived.

On one of my first public nights out in Budapest after returning, I approached a woman in a nightlife venue. It was Thursday. She looked at me with a grimace, and the expression hit me as culture shock. In places such as Adams Morgan, I had known strangers to smile and sometimes approach first. Now I was back in my own city and could no longer read a room I was supposed to know.

By Saturday, I was organizing Thailand. Within days, I had left. Her expression was one of the reasons I fled into travel so quickly. I was escaping the feeling that Budapest had become foreign to me after I came home.

Still, I tried.

The first rebuff was not the only public-room memory. On another night, I moved toward a woman. Before I could say a word, she exclaimed, "Well, not you!" The sentence closed the space before a conversation began. It remains one person's boundary in one moment, not a verdict on Budapest or Hungarian women.

Another woman was already surrounded by several people. I stepped into the group, asked for a way to contact her and then left her to continue the conversation. We later met. The meeting taught me the opposite lesson from the rejection: I had succeeded in creating a next step, yet once we were together I did not feel the

attraction I had expected. Access was not connection, and being chosen was not the same as choosing honestly.

On another evening, a woman and I danced well. I sensed that she was waiting for me to ask for her contact details. Instead, I left the venue with people I knew without saying anything to her. Afterwards they asked why I had not asked. Had I become frightened? The possibility stayed with me because this time no one had rejected me. I had disappeared from an opening myself.

I later found a useful name for part of this confusion: re-entry or reverse culture shock. A person can return expecting home to be familiar, while both the person and the remembered home have changed. I do not use the term as a diagnosis, an excuse or a comparison in which one country wins. It describes the mismatch I felt. My return to Hungary was physical long before it became social, and the missed beginnings contained my own fear as well as other people's boundaries.

I tried because I had not returned to observe my life from behind the window. I wanted a person with whom the journeys, work, ordinary evenings and future could be shared.

20. Two Kinds of Silence

 joined the apps.

Online dating contains real possibility. People meet, form relationships and build lives through it. My own experience also exposed two opposite failures of attention.

On one side, a person sends interest and waits inside silence. The phone remains still long enough for the stillness to become a verdict.

On the other side, a person receives so many messages that individual intention loses shape. Attention becomes a crowd. Reading everything requires time, filtering and safety work. Overload can look like abundance from the outside and feel like another form of impossibility from within.

Neither person is morally wrong. The system places scarcity and excess beside each other without building a bridge between them.

A photograph carries enormous weight. Age, appearance and fragments of history arrive before a voice, before a shared task, before we have seen how somebody listens, adapts, jokes, helps or respects a boundary. We form an opinion because the interface asks for one. The opinion can feel complete because no shared context exists to contradict it.

When I returned from London in December 2015, I had just turned thirty-five. For almost two years, I swiped and the phone gave me no match at all. Men crowded one side of the screen; women were fewer on the other. Thirty-five was also an edge in Tinder's age filters. They could look down the age scale toward younger men and still have another face waiting.

At thirty-seven, I changed one field on Tinder. I entered thirty-three instead of thirty-seven and left the photograph exactly as it was. The silence broke. I met women around thirty and some who had not yet reached it. Women older than the age displayed began matching one after another too.

Thirty-three and thirty-seven were four ordinary years once two people sat across a table. On the screen, the number had decided whether the table existed. The face had not changed.

One of those encounters in 2017 made that change tangible. I met a woman whose own picture caught me immediately. That response was entirely subjective; the photograph had told me almost nothing about her.

She worked in financial advisory for a multinational investment bank. During our conversation, she asked why I did not try applying there. I answered indirectly. Money was not the real obstacle. I had still not closed London inside myself. I was living in Hungary, but I was not yet fully here.

From my side, the date felt good. She did not want another. I never learned why. I wondered whether something about me had felt wrong to her, but that was only my attempt to explain an answer I did not have. She did not close the door to continuing the chat, yet a second conversation never happened.

This was still before I officially re-registered in Hungary on 10 November 2018. The encounter did not decide that return on its own, but it nudged me. If I was going to live in Hungary, I could not remain indefinitely outside its ordinary systems while still facing London. I would eventually have to register myself back into Hungarian life and begin looking for work here.

The old world was not automatically kinder. Introductions through friends could exclude, gossip and reproduce closed circles. A person in common could be wrong. Nostalgia is not a product requirement.

What I missed was the useful human function inside an introduction: context before verdict.

21. Rooms Full of Beginnings

 did not remain behind the phone.

I went to talks, community dinners, language and social evenings, exhibitions, events and other rooms where people had chosen to appear in public. Each room contained beginnings.

A woman I had once dated told me about an unnamed friendship-centred event community in Budapest. After returning from London, I began attending its events occasionally, though never regularly. I had come home alone, and this was one of the places that eased the loneliness. Its identity was broader than dating: it tried to create an open social environment through varied gatherings rather than asking every arrival to carry a romantic purpose. Some formats deliberately mixed strangers so established circles did not close the room. Over time, the community spread beyond one city.

I also went there hoping to find a partner. In the events I attended, people arrived as single adults, yet that shared status did not become an effective path toward a relationship for me. I never knew exactly why. Perhaps the crowd was too large. Perhaps a recurring community made people guard themselves more carefully because nobody wanted an approach or refusal to become group gossip. Perhaps a friendship-centred room made romantic intention feel too exposed. Contact existed, but there was no private reciprocal signal and supported next step that I could recognize and use.

For me, it worked for almost everything else. It gave me somewhere to go so I did not always have to be alone, and I came to know a few people. It offered programs, familiar faces, shared interests, acquaintances and friendship. It did not lead me to the partner I had also gone there hoping to find. That is a personal outcome, not evidence that nobody else formed a relationship there.

Some of those beginnings did continue. Around shared interests, a recognizable group formed and friendship remained. Romance did not grow from it, but friendship was not a lesser result. It was one of the things I had been looking for without always knowing how to name it.

Other short conversations were pleasant, intelligent and genuine, yet the event ended, the crowd changed, and the beginning had no supported next step.

This did not mean the events had failed. A friendship is not failed dating, and a lecture is allowed to be a lecture. A volunteer group is not a dating market. A person attending a cultural evening has not consented to be evaluated romantically. The problem was not that every door should lead to a relationship. The problem was that, when two or more people did want continuation, the structure often disappeared exactly when it became necessary.

Who asks? How is mutual intention expressed without public embarrassment? What happens when somebody is interested but unavailable? Where do people meet? Who chooses the place, checks the time, manages the route and gives everybody a clear way to decline?

We have many systems for discovery. We have fewer systems for continuation.

22. The Beginner Floor

Dance classes gave me another version of the same lesson.

At the beginner level, the floor was full. People missed steps, recovered, laughed and changed partners because the instructor had made movement between strangers legitimate. The shared task carried conversation. Nobody needed to invent a reason to stand near another person; the music and the lesson had already created one.

At the advanced level, the room thinned. Novelty had passed. Schedules, difficulty and other priorities reduced the group.

Sometimes a conversation with a woman began warmly. Then her partner arrived, folded an umbrella and greeted us. The context became clear. Nothing terrible happened. Nobody had deceived or humiliated me. I adjusted, smiled and stepped back.

The lesson was not that partnered people had occupied the wrong room. The lesson was that context arrived late.

Dance showed what an app profile could not: rhythm, patience, humour, recovery after error, comfort with proximity and respect for another person's movement. It also showed that shared activity is not the same as romantic availability.

A better path would need both truths at once.

23. The Wrong Room for a Date

 ates happened too.

Sometimes the person was not the problem. The room was.

In a loud café, an espresso machine could erase the most important half of a sentence. In a basement bar, music turned conversation into repeated apology: “Sorry—what did you say?” At an elegant restaurant, a beautiful table could make two ordinary people sit as if they were being examined. Visible prices, interruptions and formal duration gave a first meeting the weight of a final decision.

The opposite side of a city could consume more time than the date itself. Weather could destroy a scenic plan with no fallback. A skill-based activity could give one person confidence and the other an hour of public failure.

Chemistry does not occur outside logistics. Light, noise, cost, travel, timing, alcohol, accessibility, weather and the ability to leave all shape the meeting.

Finding a person was only the beginning. The meeting still needed somewhere it could breathe.

24. A Whole Person Behind the Frame

By then I had tried enough doors to stop blaming the existence of doors.

Apps offered reach. Events offered presence. Dance offered shared action. Travel offered openness. Friends of friends offered context. Each route contained real value. Each lost continuity at a different boundary.

The common failure appeared on the notebook page.

Before meeting, we reduced one another to filters: age, appearance, biography, distance, a short sentence, a delayed reply. After meeting, a person became three-dimensional again. We could see how somebody treated a waiter, waited for a slower walker, solved a practical problem, spoke when nervous, listened when another person needed space, and changed when the plan changed.

A picture is powerful. It is also thin.

The whole person includes difficulty. Housing insecurity, money, distance, health, age, fear and past disappointment do not automatically disqualify somebody from relationship. The question was not how to hide imperfection, but how to prevent one visible problem from becoming the whole verdict before two people had shared enough reality to understand it. Only then could acceptance, boundaries and mutual effort be tested together.

I have come to believe that most people are not asking to be declared flawless. They are asking not to be reduced to the first visible problem before anybody knows them. They want acceptance: not automatic approval of every action, and not the surrender of another person's safety or boundaries, but the chance to be seen as a whole human being. Only then can two people decide freely whether they can continue together.

Acceptance and speed are not opposites. We do not have infinite time. Endless catalogues and unmanageable queues of conversations do not become humane merely by delaying choice. The question is not whether choices are made, but what they are allowed to reduce a person to.

I did not want to hide age or pretend that preferences do not exist. I wanted older adults to remain full participants rather than disappear from the visual and social field. Age could remain truthful context without becoming the public value of a human being.

Nobody needed to tell people whom to love.

Mutual intention needed somewhere real to go.



MYSCOUTEE ORIGIN STORY

Part Five — Drawing the Path



25. The Idea from 2016

 he idea that became MyScoutee dates to 2016.

It did not arrive as a finished interface or a sudden revelation generated by a machine. It accumulated through years of observation: crowded houses, unmatched capacity, short-lived travel networks, silent phones, overloaded phones, rooms full of beginnings, late-arriving context and plans that failed because one person lacked one day.

Back in Budapest, I gave long periods of my life to creative work in private. From the December 2015 return until the 10 November 2018 re-entry threshold, I withdrew far enough that the work became almost invisible from outside. I travelled, searched for a partner, returned, opened the notebook and kept trying to give the problem a form. The 2016 idea belongs inside this period of guarded independence, an unresolved London return and an unfinished attempt to make life in my homeland work differently.

That independence mattered because work of this scale could not have been built in the fragments left beside an ordinary full-time job. The idea has now occupied a long span of calendar time, but I did not spend ten continuous years developing it. What financial independence gave me was something more precise: the right to create sustained periods of attention. Without it, even the concentrated weeks needed to turn the idea into a broad system would not have been available.

The problem was not “How do I create another dating app?”

It was:

> *How can a relationship travel from unknown possibility to a real meeting, while every person keeps the right to decide?*

That question is harder than matching two profiles. It includes intention, reciprocity, capacity, context, conversation, place, transport, resources, attendance, memory and change over time.

Later, artificial intelligence accelerated implementation. It helped me work at a speed that made a broad software core possible. It did not invent the human insight. It did not validate the product, produce a community or prove that the system improves relationships. Faster construction is not the same as evidence.

The notebook still had to meet the world.

26. Priority Is Not Human Value



The first product decision is deliberately private.

A user can give an unknown individual or pair an editable priority from one to ten. The number is not attractiveness, morality, reputation or public human value. It is a statement about the user's current willingness to allocate scarce attention.

Binary choice hides important differences. Curiosity is not the same as strong interest. Strong interest is not the same as present capacity. A person may care and still lack time. A person may become more or less interested as context changes.

The priority can change because people change. A first encounter may confirm an earlier impression, weaken it or make somebody newly important. Private input can change with experience; the system need not preserve one frozen match.

No single person's rating determines the next meeting. Other people's private inputs, reciprocity, availability, distance and a fresh accept-or-decline choice still matter. The algorithm proposes a changing path through shared intention; it does not issue a social verdict.

Automated or contextual signals may contribute, but nobody is owed a meeting. A strong preference from one person cannot pull another into a group. Every invitation still requires an independent decision.

This matters because software is tempted to make its own calculation look more important than the humans inside it. The interface should not display a giant graph declaring compatibility. The mechanism belongs in the background. Faces, choices and real meetings belong in front.

The system is meant to be a rapid filter, not a rapid verdict on human worth. Private priority, reciprocity, distance and context can narrow the field enough to offer a small candidate group. Independent acceptance moves willing people toward conversation and a real meeting instead of infinite browsing.

The machine accelerates the path to human context. It does not replace the human decision that becomes possible there. Whether this produces better outcomes still has to be tested with real communities.

27. Six Strangers

In the clearest form of the story, the system proposes a balanced candidate group of six strangers: three women and three men.



Six separate inner worlds before the first shared meeting.

The group is not an accidental presentation layer. It changes the risk carried by the meeting. A two-person date can place the entire value of an evening on one immediate romantic outcome. If chemistry does not appear, both people may experience the time as wasted. A group can support several conversations, a shared activity, future friendship or another invitation even when one possible pair does not continue.

A larger group also makes more kinds of real-world activity practical. People can share a place, transport, supplies, cost, knowledge and responsibility. The event has a purpose larger than evaluating one person across a table.

They are not six copies of one desirable profile. The group reflects the people I currently imagine using the idea most: adults whose work, relocation, changing friendships or search for a partner has made social time harder to organize. Many may be in their thirties, forties or fifties, but that is a working picture, not an age rule. Someone in their twenties or sixties may fit just as naturally when the event and mutual interest make sense. They also differ in body, ethnicity, temperament, clothing and expectation. Each arrives with a life of their own and a different reason for accepting the invitation.



The same six strangers, now visible as individuals.

Before the meeting, each person carries a separate inner world. One imagines a book. Another a shared meal. Another music, a route, a tabletop game or a place to sketch. A candidate group does not mean they are already friends. It means there is enough reciprocal intention and context to ask a better question.

Each person receives an invitation. Each may accept or decline without public punishment.

If the group proceeds, separate panels become a contextual group chat. The chat is not the destination. It is the preparation for a doorway.

At that doorway, the six introduce themselves.

The product's most important transformation is not a swipe becoming a match. It is a stranger becoming somebody who has actually been met.

28. The First Managed Event

A real event needs more than a title. People, transport, place, accommodation and supplies must become one plan. The distinction sounds technical until one missing key, ticket or ride ends the evening before it begins.

The principle is do-it-yourself (DIY) first, not DIY only. A host may assemble the whole event, share parts with local providers or choose a managed plan from an organizer. Participants retain the same right to accept or decline in every case.

Who is coming? How will they travel? Is the venue appropriate? Who has the key? What must be brought? Does somebody need a ticket? Did the person actually arrive? What did the participants experience afterward?

The event should be public enough to feel legible, hosted enough to feel intentional and flexible enough to let a person leave. A quiet conversation area matters. So does a visible entrance. Accessibility should be designed into the route rather than reduced to an invented pictogram.

The six strangers contribute to a shared task. One checks transport. One confirms the place. One brings supplies. Two discover a joke. One listens before speaking. The Founder is part of the group, not its centre.



The decisive transition is not a swipe becoming a match, but a stranger becoming somebody met.

Nothing guarantees romance. That is not failure.

If six people meet, learn enough to recognize one another and choose whether to continue, the system has carried intention into reality. Chemistry finally has somewhere to happen—or not happen—without asking one stranger to justify the entire evening.

29. After Strangers Become Known

After the first meeting, the product state should change because the human state has changed.

Every real encounter returns new information to the people who were present. Their personal intuitions can become private rate changes: up after trust, interest or an unexpectedly good conversation; down after discomfort, disagreement or a sense that continuation would not be right. Those evolving inputs help determine dynamically which future group or event paths become more or less likely.

These are no longer abstract profiles. They are known contacts with a place and time in common. They can be invited directly to later events. A person in common or a previous event can make the next invitation less cold without becoming a public character reference or guarantee of safety.

If one person lacks time and declines, the planner may offer the open place to somebody else who still chooses independently. People are not replacement parts; changing availability need not destroy the whole social path, and no algorithm can manufacture consent.

Repeated meetings may become community. Community is the result, not the input.

Relationships may also weaken. An ordinary disagreement can lower one private priority and make a future shared route less likely. No revenge score follows. No public reputation is damaged. The network remembers context without becoming gossip.

This is a living social graph, not a completed matching result. A person may meet somebody again, meet one of that person's known contacts, or enter a different balanced group as private rates and real availability change. Every new proposal still ends in independent human consent.

The whole life of a relationship matters: unknown person, private intention, reciprocal group, conversation, first meeting, known contact, later invitation, repetition, change.

Most systems celebrate the beginning. Human life continues after it.

30. One Shared Core, Many Local Souls

My travels taught me that global reach without local meaning is only movement.

The system therefore should not become one central culture distributed around the world. The core problem may be shared: how do mutual intention and available capacity become a real meeting? The answer still belongs to local people.

Localization means more here than translating labels. The current core can use distance and location context and can carry an event through a real place, transport, timing and other resources. The operator model adds another local layer: language, culture, venues, boundaries, partnerships and community knowledge. It does not make geography disappear or claim to replace a complete travel planner. A few-hour Debrecen–Budapest date can still depend on two timetables and one narrow window. The product's task is to make that constraint visible early enough to coordinate a humane plan.

Changing countries makes speed more important. A person arrives with finite time and often without a usable local network. The ambition is that the same group-first path can be available again under a new city's language, places, culture and operator, so relocation does not require inventing the route to human context from nothing.

The present architecture does not yet carry a person's private history seamlessly between independent operators. Its honest promise is continuity of method, not automatic movement of intimate records. A local network may be built faster; it still requires new consent.

A local operator can run the shared core under a local brand, with local communities, language, venues, knowledge and responsibility. Operators may cooperate through a voluntary network, but leaving it must not destroy the local community.

The common core should reduce duplicated technical effort. It should not erase local authorship.

The unnamed friendship-centred community I attended had already taught me that a strong local event culture could spread to more places. It was one source of inspiration, not the blueprint. Its expansion carried an organizer-led social identity outward. MyScoutee is designed to scale differently: the shared layer is technical, while each operator owns the local social identity. That is an architectural intention, not proof that the network will succeed.

A city walk in Budapest, a dance-linked group in London, a one-day coach toward the High Tatras, a community table in Lisbon or a cultural event in Cairo cannot be made meaningful by the same visual template alone. Local organizers know the pace, boundaries, costs, trust signals, transport and places. Participants create the actual event through their decisions.

Global route. Local encounter.

The principle returns at the end because it was present from the beginning.

31. What Is Built, What Is Not Proven

The software core is broad. It contains private priorities, contextual and reciprocal group planning, invitations, chat, events, schedules, policies, resources, ticket and check-in paths, feedback, notifications, moderation, administration, branding and operator controls.

Breadth is not traction.

Code does not prove that strangers will accept a proposal, attend the event, feel comfortable, return or form relationships. It does not prove improved safety, superior matching, revenue or product-market fit.

The next work is less cinematic and more important: performance and mobile hardening, safety and privacy review, real-world testing, one dense pilot, measurement from proposal through acceptance, chat, event, attendance and feedback, and a launch process that a local operator can repeat.

That requires partners:

- technically capable local operators;
- pilot communities willing to test the complete path;
- product collaborators;
- venue, activity, travel and experience partners;
- later strategic partners who understand the difference between built scope and proven outcomes.

I am not looking for somebody to admire the notebook.

I am looking for people willing to test the path.

Epilogue — The Star Above the Open Space

 he MyScoutee mark contains a helmet-like shelter, a star and an open human space at its centre.

I do not treat it as a guarantee. A logo cannot certify safety, direction or connection. It can only hold an intention.

When I close the cognac notebook, the routes do not disappear. The field row is still inside the rail line. Budapest is still beautiful. The hostel corridor, the London window, the shared bedroom, the one-pound coach, the fallen luggage, the balloon in the vegetable plot, the bus voice behind me in Agra, the Russian passenger's card, the local ride to the pier, the bridges inside the gorge and the six chairs around a real table remain connected by memory.

For years, I believed the central problem was finding the right person.

Now I believe the world already contains more possible connection than we can see. The missing element is often the path: context before verdict, intention without public humiliation, coordination without coercion, memory without gossip, and enough local humanity to turn a route into a meeting.

The path cannot manufacture acceptance. It can give acceptance a fairer chance to become mutual, informed and real.

After many interviews, I found a multinational position in Hungary in August 2019. I had come close to retreating to London again; by chance, I no longer had to. The position looked stable. COVID-19 quickly destroyed that expectation.

The same pandemic opened a different door: cross-border remote work. I secured a contract role connected to another multinational in Brussels. It had looked less stable than the Hungarian position, yet proved more durable. Without the new remote arrangement, I would have had to move abroad again. Professionally, I was already standing with one foot beyond the border while still living at home.

In my experience, 2021 was the one open year. Once the pandemic receded, a remote arrangement already secured could remain if the company did not require personal attendance. In 2022, as an unknown new applicant, I was no longer being accepted on the same terms.

What followed belongs to Part II.

Years ago, another Indian colleague in the London office told me that I should write a novel.

I did not write it then.

I am writing it now.

My story does not end with a perfect match.

It ends with an invitation.

MyScoutee. Test it with me in real communities.



MYSCOUTEE ORIGIN STORY

Notes on Memory, Geography, and Product Truth



This section is intentionally separate from the memoir voice. It records the main public sources and truth boundaries used for this edition.

Budapest and Its Surroundings

- The Banks of the Danube, Buda Castle District and Andrássy Avenue form Budapest's UNESCO-listed urban landscape.
- Official Budapest cultural material supports the presence of the Hungarian National Gallery, Museum of Fine Arts, National Museum, Ludwig Museum, Kunsthalle, thermal baths, caves and the Zugliget Chairlift.
- Official Greater Budapest material supports Szentendre, Visegrád, Esztergom and Gödöllő as credible nearby day-trip anchors.

Sources:

- https://whc.unesco.org/en/list/400/
- https://visithungary.com/articles/budapest-you_re-wonderful
- https://www.budapestinfo.hu/en/spring-exhibition-guide-in-budapest
- https://visithungary.com/articles/visegrad-citadel
- https://visithungary.com/trip/greater-budapest-for-explorers---1-day

Thiruvananthapuram and the First India Assignment

- Thiruvananthapuram is also known as Trivandrum. Official district material places Kerala's capital near the extreme south of India's west coast, across low coastal hills beside the Arabian Sea.
- Kerala Tourism places the Western Ghats/highlands to the east and northeast and documents a district containing coastline, backwaters and both prominent and quieter beach environments.
- The cornfield hiring moment, roughly six-week assignment, Irish–Hungarian team, development of practical English and nearly tourist-free visited beach are first-person memories. The exact company, campus and beach are not named.
- “Practically no tourists” describes the particular shoreline the Founder remembers. It does not mean that the district lacked tourism; official sources document well-known visitor beaches elsewhere in the same district.

Sources:

- https://trivandrum.nic.in/en/about-district/
- https://www.keralatourism.org/districts/thiruvananthapuram/
- https://trivandrum.nic.in/en/places-of-interest/
- https://spb.kerala.gov.in/economic-review/ER2012/Chapter5/chapter05.html

London, Migration, and Return

- The exact household, lunch, work, housing and journey details are first-person memories.
- Ocean City, Virginia, Philadelphia, Washington, New York, Niagara Falls, Amish country, Six Flags east of the Washington–Baltimore corridor and a mountain-top Indian Trail farther inland to the west are the Founder's route. The precise park, Amish settlement and hotel are not needed by the story.
- The United States assignment, promised-but-unreceived overtime payment, return to and continued work in the Hungarian office, later friction and departure around September 2010, six-and-a-half-month unemployment period, final four-round Hungarian interview and London job within two weeks are also first-person memories. Employers remain anonymous, and the account makes no legal finding.
- The hearing and corridor exchange after the overtime dispute are first-person memories. The passage records the Founder's loss of trust after hearing a possible job for his lawyer's son discussed with the office manager; it does not allege bribery, professional misconduct or a proved connection with the merits or outcome of the overtime dispute.
- The health chronology is first-person testimony: blood in the Founder's stool appeared during the American period's extreme work pressure; he associated it with that pressure; he moved to London in 2011 while still experiencing it; his Hungarian public-health-insurance coverage was no longer active; and he received medical care in London. No diagnosis, clinical detail, independent causation finding or comparative health-system claim is made.
- London begins in 2011. The Diamond Jubilee and Olympic summer belong to 2012, the following year, and are preserved as atmosphere rather than an arrival date.
- Practical English beginning in Trivandrum and weak conversational English in early London are compatible: the Founder reports that he could barely speak with colleagues for almost three years despite being able to perform the job.
- A different Indian woman colleague at the same workplace once told the Founder to write a novel. The Founder worked at that one London workplace throughout his five years there. She is not the colleague from the farewell-gift memory.
- The wedding invitation from a Black London colleague and the Founder's decision not to attend are first-person memory. The passage records his own uncertainty and fear of exposing culture shock; it makes no claim about the ceremony, the colleague's expectations or a uniform Black British culture.
- The impression that perhaps one person in three around the household no longer wanted to return is explicitly not a population statistic.
- The roughly eight-year “disappeared” arc runs from the September 2010 employer departure to 10 November 2018. It was not continuous physical absence from Hungary. The phrase describes the

Founder's experience of institutional invisibility and does not claim that authorities could not locate him.

- Research on return migration shows mixed experiences: foreign experience and language may be valued, while skill mismatch, weakened networks and employer stereotypes can also exist. No specific employer motive is asserted here.
- The 2017 photograph, date, employment conversation and unfinished chat are first-person memories. The investment bank remains unnamed. The Founder says only that the date felt good to him; he does not know why the woman declined a second date. The encounter occurred before the 10 November 2018 Hungarian health-insurance re-registration and was one nudge toward institutional re-entry, not its sole cause.
- The August 2019 Hungarian multinational role after many interviews, the near return to London, its rapid COVID-19-era end, the apparently less secure but more durable Brussels contract and the narrow pandemic-enabled remote-work window are first-person chronology. Both employers remain anonymous. The statement that 2021 was the only open year and that unknown new applicants no longer received the same remote opportunity in 2022 describes the Founder's own experience, not a general labour-market rule. This edition states only the threshold; its consequences belong to Part II.

Sources:

- https://washington.org/dc-neighborhoods/adams-morgan
- https://www.nps.gov/planyourvisit/cities.htm
- https://www.nps.gov/subjects/mountains/explore.htm
- https://www.visitmaryland.org/list/roller-coasters
- https://www.nps.gov/appa/planyourvisit/upload/APPA_Map.pdf
- https://home.nps.gov/cato/planyourvisit/catoctin-national-recreation-trail.htm
- https://a.storyblok.com/f/279033/86106655bd/ef1243en.pdf
- https://www.oecd.org/content/dam/oecd/en/publications/reports/2020/10/sustainable-reintegration-of-returning-migrants_86be9bc5/5fee55b3-en.pdf
- https://ojs.mtak.hu/index.php/hungeobull/article/view/595

Selected Journey Anchors

- The Founder has identified the North Wales low-tide place as Barmouth. The exact visual perspective remains a first-person memory.
- Five people made the road circuit: two couples and the Founder. He organized the itinerary but cannot drive; an acquaintance travelling with the group drove the rented car and was not a hired driver. Budget hotels supplied the accommodation along the route. The trip lasted three days and needed a fourth to avoid the rush. Exact hotel properties are not asserted.
- The Egypt trip occurred after the London homecoming, so the memoir groups journeys thematically rather than claiming a strict film chronology.
- The five-day November 2016 Golden Triangle structure, WhatsApp-arranged driver, entrance-payment difficulty and reason for returning to northern India are first-person memories. Distance references place Agra more than 2,000 kilometres from Thiruvananthapuram even in a straight line.
- The Reserve Bank of India's 8 November 2016 notice withdrew legal-tender status from the existing series of 500- and 1,000-rupee notes from 9 November. It did not withdraw all Indian cash.
- The edition does not claim visits to specific monuments the Founder does not clearly remember.
- Minimundus is in Klagenfurt near Lake Wörthersee, not Vienna.
- Bärenschützklamm begins near Mixnitz in Styria. Official tourism material describes the route's bridges, ladders, waterfalls and demanding elevation.

Sources:

- https://www.visitwales.com/attraction/beach/barmouth-beach-528111
- https://www.barmouthtowncouncil.gov.uk/water-safety
- https://www.minimundus.at/en/
- https://www.minimundus.at/en/location-how-to-get-here/
- https://www.steiermark.com/en/Oststeiermark/Plan-your-holiday/Tours/Through-the-Barenschutzklamm-from-Mixnitz_tour_30999545
- https://www.schoenbrunn.at/en/
- https://whc.unesco.org/en/list/87
- https://www.travelmath.com/distance/from/Thiruvananthapuram%2C%2BIndia/to/Agra%2C%2BIndia
- https://www.makemytrip.com/flights/trivandrum-agra-distance.html
- https://systemhealth.rbi.org.in/Scripts/BS_PressReleaseDisplay.aspx_prid%3D38520%281%29.html

Age and Digital Dating

- Age discrimination is not presented as uniquely Hungarian or absent abroad.
- MyScoutee does not hide age and does not claim to solve ageism. The bounded product principle is continued agency and context before premature verdict.

Sources:

- https://op.europa.eu/webpub/empl/lmwd-annual-review-report-2024/chapter3/the-labour-force-participation-and-employment.html
- https://www.uoc.edu/en/news/2024/digital-ageism-on-dating-apps

Product Claims

The product descriptions in this book are based on the current MyScoutee repository and pitch materials. Built scope is not evidence of users, revenue, retention, safety improvement, relationship outcomes, deployed operators or product-market fit. The operator network is an intended model to be tested.

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